

How Digital Photography is Changing the World

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Abstract: The innovation of digital photography has fundamentally changed the way humans think, act, and document. This research paper examines the profound social, psychological, and cultural impacts of digital photography's widespread use since Steven Sasson invented the first digital camera in 1975. Through analysis of academic and journalistic sources, this paper explores the major areas that digital photography has transformed. From the effects of digital photography on social media that affect self-esteem, to memory formation when documenting images, to the shift from film to digital photography and its implications for the practice of photography. While digital photography has enabled unprecedented documentation and citizen journalism, it has also contributed to unrealistic beauty standards and altered human cognition, representing a fundamental shift in how humanity experiences visual memory.

Introduction

Starting in the 16th century, archaic forms of capturing an image on a wall to be sketched over were the first signs of a new innovation called photography. Starting with capturing an image through light and chemicals, Photography was an analogue task that would take hours to complete (Dell'Oso, 2021). As time progressed, the technology began to develop. Photos went from something that took hours to a click of a button. Film capsules could hold up to 36 images and would be sent to a dark room and be developed into pictures that can be held in a photo album in a multi-day process. Then in 1975, employee of Kodak cameras, Steven Sasson, invented the first digital camera, a large clunky box that was able to capture the scenes from film photography and record it digitally (de Castella, 2012). This technology took the world by storm, with innovations in compression of photos and the actual cameras making them smaller and cheaper. From then on, photography became something that was available to all people, unlimited, and sharable in the new digital era.

Digital photography has become a ubiquitous part of human society, a worldwide tool that has become universal, no matter what cultural barriers there may be. Photography fills a need within human psychology that fits core human cognitive and social mechanisms (Kislinger & Kotrschal, 2021). With the dissemination of smartphones globally, the addition of a mobile camera has accelerated the amount of digital photos to be in the trillions. What has become from this omnipresence is a profoundly human reaction to the advent of digital photography as a technology. From this technology, human psychology has changed to have radical responses to what they see online, what is documented through images, and how people consume

photography on a daily basis. Through digital photography, the basis of society has fundamentally changed the way that people act, behave, and document things.

Social Media

Social media has become the largest engine in this social upheaval, with the aspect of digital photography being easily edited and shared being the main catalyst. Social networking sites have changed the way people share what they do and what they look like to lighting fast speeds and a global reach.

A feature that photos can be easily taken, changed, and shared has given human brains a confusing time differentiating between memories that have been recorded, and memories that have been experienced. An article written by Regina Nogueira (2020) of Birkbeck College, University of London entitled “How does digital photography affect the way we remember and perceive ourselves” argues that people experience events differently due to the allure of posting and recording activities, rather than recalling memories regularly, the algorithmic and ease of getting photographs has depleted that human function. What this means is that simply using a digital camera and storing photos takes part in changing the fundamental tool of the human brain to accept that a photo memory bank could be used as another storage device for the human mind. In society, what this cognitive realization potentially means is that humans are becoming more reliant on this new technology as a filler for things that they would like to cherish.

Furthermore, photo editing has changed the way people that post and share digital photos online think about themselves. A paper written by Ruhr-Universität Bochum researchers Phillip Ozimek et al. (2023), named “How photo editing in social media shapes self-perceived attractiveness and self-esteem via self-objectification and physical appearance comparisons”

examines how photo editing and digital photo dissemination online has changed self-esteem and perceived attractiveness. From this dissertation, the researchers estimate that 50% of users on social media network sites upload their photos edited. This normalization of photo editing has created a cause and effect relationship where people that upload photos feel the need to edit their photos from seeing photos that are edited, but lower their self esteem. What this negative relationship changes in society is that it decreases the mental health of the online population worldwide through comparisons and unrealistic standards. From this negativity, society functions around social media sites and blurs the line between what is fake and real.

The main social change that has become from digital photography has been how the world has been radically altered through social media platforms and their ability to share edited images. Through this function, the way memories of humans worldwide have been recorded has changed as well as the self-esteem of people online.

Film to Digital

Next, one of the largest things to come from the advent of digital photography is the regression of film photography. This medium of photography, which has been the majority of the history of photography, has slowly become a subculture within the space of photography rather than the all encompassing medium that it has been.

What this regression has sparked is the debate between photographers using digital photography vs. film photography. Writer Rithika Sentilkumar (2018) from the Massachusetts Daily Collegian argues in her article “Is digital photography making photographs less meaningful?” that photographers should weigh their decision to use either medium. In her article Sentilkumar argues that the limited nature of analogue photography makes the physical feeling of

images worth more. Through the argument presented in this writing, using film photography makes the memories generated by digital photography feel like fleeting moments in comparison to the permanence of a developed photographic item. Ramifications for this new debate signal humanity's move away from permanent and tangible objects stored in photo albums to digital items that can be uploaded to the cloud. What this means is that as innovations like digital photography progress, the things that people hold dear can potentially be digitized and devalue the various things that are bequeathed onto younger generations.

On the other hand of this debate is the change in ways that photographers think. Since everyone has been able to become a so-called photographer, the differences between amateurs and professionals has diminished greatly (Siri et al. 2022). Furthermore, the actual way photographers think now has gone from a practice focused on quality to a focus on the quantity of photos that can be taken. The commonality of photos has made it so that of the trillions of photos, few photographers can truly shine the way legends like Ansel Adams and Andrew Bernstein could. While photographers might not be as impactful, the best photos of the trillions of photographers truly shine, according to Sagnik Banerjee's (2017) article "The Digital Age- The End of Photography or a New Beginning?" In his blog, Banerjee argues that even though photos have become less significant as they number in the trillions, the few photos that can go viral are some of the most impactful photos on the planet. To put it another way, the value of artists has gone down, while the artistic ability has risen. What this means for society is that the barrier to become a photographer is now lowered, anyone with a smartphone camera can refer to themselves as a photographer. The simple nature of capturing an image in the 16th century has been compressed in the pockets of modern people.

Positive Outcomes

Finally, the positive aspects of digital photography have balanced or surpassed the negatives that are associated with the innovation. While social media sharing has shown to be detrimental to mental health, the routine of showing positive activities has shown to outweigh the negativity of other digital media. Photo journalism has allowed every person with a camera to document and share experiences that would otherwise be covered up or ignored.

Beginning with the mental health betterment of society, practices of using digital photography to document positive things in one's life is shown to benefit mental health. In a study conducted by Liz Brewster & Andrew Cox (2018) of Lancaster & Sheffield University titled “The daily digital practice as a form of self-care: Using photography for everyday well-being” it showed that having a daily practice of posting positive activities online can help one's mental wellbeing. By using social media to post digital photos not to compare and rather to share positive activities like exercise, writing, or photography, participants' mental health is shown to improve. In a way, the radicalization of mental health as a result of social media habits can be either positive or negative.

Secondly, the ability of everyone to document moments on their phone has resulted in citizen journalism through recording digital media to explode. This has allowed events that would not have been documented by journalists to be documented by citizens. For example, those that have documented unbelievable events can be credited for their work in assisting in natural disasters, crimes, and other newsworthy actions. Videos of animals that may not be seen in other places are being able to be experienced thousands of miles away. As a result, humanity has seen a boost in positive journalism from the invention of the digital camera.

Conclusion

In conclusion, digital photography has made plenty of impacts on human society. Whether it be the positive or negative ramifications on human mental health through the instant editing and sharing of digitized photos, the ability of everyone to be a photographer and photo journalist, and the divide between digital and analog photography, all have been affected on a global scale by this innovation. To further deepen understanding of how digital photography changed the world, research should be done into how people have changed how they react to film photography and digital photography. From this investigation, the two kinds of photography can be thoroughly compared to understand the different types of photos shot, did the emotion of images change from then to now? This allows us to compare how different society was before the advent of the technology to how it is today. It would further understand how photojournalism compared to the past and modern times, how the difference of documentation changed the way people react from then and now. From this conclusion, the exact time the way society changed could be determined and the basic understanding of what changed. Without digital photography, our world would look much different than it is today, society would likely have moved in a different direction than it has and peoples lives would look very different than they would today.

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